

Everyone Wants More

Even though I know practically anyone can become a millionaire over time at almost any income level, I'm not stupid. I know that more money can make it easier to reach your goals. You'll become a millionaire a lot faster with a \$100,000 salary than you will with a \$50,000 salary, right? Well, maybe—and maybe not. If you're sitting at \$35,000 or even \$60,000, you may think all your problems would be over if you hit the six-figure mark. Many families who have gotten there, though, have been disappointed by what they discovered. NPR ran a story in which they interviewed several families who earn more than \$100,000 a year. Their question was simple: "What does living on \$100,000 a year look like?" You may be surprised at what they found. Emma Bowman, who reported on the findings for NPR, explained, "On paper, that kind of salary is considered well-off. But as we heard from many, it often takes just one major expense for that to not feel like enough."¹⁹

One family they interviewed acknowledged their \$100,000 income made them "far from destitute," but then said they had recently declared bankruptcy because they couldn't pay their bills. Despite their high income, they were forced to take extra jobs and admitted, "We haven't been able to do Christmas in ten years. We don't even have a tree."²⁰ Another six-figure family reported, "It's embarrassing to say that you have to work overtime in order to make enough money to live on . . . working second jobs and even third jobs to try to put together the money just to stay in the middle class where [we've] been in the past."²¹ Family after family reported big incomes and the same amount of debt, stress, and anxiety—if not more—than they'd had when their incomes were much lower.

Hearing families whine about *only* making \$100,000 can be confusing—not to mention infuriating—to families making it work on half that. Even though these high-income families seem completely out of control, though, I understand where they're coming from. The problem they're having is the